Chinese government needed to outline its "international obligations" before expecting recognition.[65]

American policymakers had been aware of Nehru's attitude toward China and the gap between US and Indian perceptions. Even before the visit, some voices within the administration had noted, "There is little hope that Nehru will dramatically announce that he has seen the light."[66] Henderson had noted that a survey of elite Indian opinion on China had shown that the majority of the leadership shared the prime minister's views.[67] Furthermore, reports from American diplomats in Delhi and Nanking had made evident that American and Indian attitudes toward the Chinese communists did not fully overlap.[68]

Nehru's visit, with public hints that Delhi was close to recognizing the communist regime in China,[69] made clear to the American public what had been apparent to some observers within the administration: the US might have assigned India a role in its strategic script, but India was not willing to play that role in the way the US wanted.[70] As the British ambassador in Washington noted, the visit "made abundantly clear to the American public that they could not look to India as a ready-made replacement for China [in] the cold war against Communism."[71] Speaking to the US Congress, Nehru had asserted, "Where freedom is menaced … or where aggression takes place, we cannot and shall not be neutral."[72] But as the *New York Times* lamented, Nehru "declined to encourage the slightest hope" that the US would have an ally in India.[73] The "fall" of China had created a constituency for India in Washington among the public and Congress; Nehru's visit limited its hopes and size.

Within the administration, the visit cemented the view that India was not necessarily the answer to its China problem—certainly not one that would justify half a billion dollars of aid at a time when resources were limited, congressional support was uncertain, and the Truman administration's focus and the public's attention remained on Europe.[74] There was also a developing change in emphasis in US policy from economic to military assistance. Thus, in the week after Nehru's visit, Henderson's proposal for a large aid package to India was set aside.[75]

Overall, Nehru's visit limited the US view of India's importance. The shift in the administration's attitude was evident in the National Security Council staff's December 1949 draft position paper on Asia policy (NSC